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Transportation barriers and equity: Values and experiences of elected officials

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ABSTRACT

Despite the importance of elected officials in shaping transportation policies, there has been little direct research on their values and experiences. Understanding the values of elected officials is particularly important in the context of transportation equity, which is fundamentally concerned with the distribution of benefits across communities and geographies. This research draws on a survey and in-depth interviews with local elected officials in Canada to understand their experiences and how they view transportation equity issues. We find that elected officials have little direct experience with transportation barriers, with few experiencing issues such as unaffordability, disability, or harassment, and evidence that this influences their values related to equity. While there was widespread agreement with values such as procedural equity, there was limited support for prioritizing marginalized communities in transportation investments, and this support varied by experience and identities. These findings point to a significant disconnect between academic/professional discourses on transportation equity and the values of elected officials. This underscores the need for addressing political contexts in understanding transportation decision-making and offering deeper understandings of the motivations and values of elected officials.

KEYWORDS

Urban planning; urban politics; inequality; transportation

Despite decades of research on transportation equity, there has been little examination into how the values and experiences of elected officials influence transportation decision-making and policy development. This absence is significant given that the distribution of transportation benefits is mediated through elected officials, policy actors who are instrumental in framing the goals, priorities, and implementation of transportation investments and policies (Edwards & Mackett, 1996; Hay & Trinder, 1991; Lee, 2023; Taylor et al., 2009). There are often critical differences in transportation priorities both between politicians and transportation experts (Cohen-Blankshtain, 2021; Taylor et al., 2009), and between policymakers and those dependent on transportation systems (Hazelton-Boyle & Wellman, 2022; Taylor & Morris, 2015). In the case of public transit, some have pointed to “a fundamental mismatch between who is making key transit decisions ... and who is most affected by those decisions” (TransitCenter, 2022, p. 5).

While elected officials are key to policy implementation, including in the success or failure of equity-focused policies (Wellman, 2016), their understandings of equity may be ambiguous (Hay & Trinder, 1991). Despite this, scholars note that as a field rooted in a technical-rational model, transportation research often treats politicians and policymakers as “exogenous to the decision-making process,” rather than seeking to understand the complexity of political contexts, power, and legitimacy that inform policy implementation and decision-making (Marsden & Reardon, 2017,

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p. 245). Given that decision makers may not reflect the populations they serve (Voulgaris et al., 2024), or have experience with the significant impacts of transportation barriers, there are questions about how values and experiences inform decision making (Cairney et al., 2016; Hazelton-Boyle & Wellman, 2022). Understanding how elected officials frame and prioritize issues is particularly important in the context of transportation equity, which is fundamentally concerned with power and fairness in the distribution of benefits and burdens.

The paucity of information about how elected officials frame decisions about transportation investments leads to knowledge gaps in how to achieve equitable transportation outcomes in practice. Despite the importance of transportation in ensuring equitable access to opportunities (Blumenberg, 2004; Linovski et al., 2021; Pereira et al., 2017), and evidence on the instrumental role that elected officials play in shaping transportation policies (Taylor et al., 2009), there is little research that specifically assesses whether and how politicians value transportation equity (Hay & Trinder, 1991). Critically, this research fills important knowledge and practice gaps by examining how local elected officials understand transportation equity, then highlighting the implications of these understandings for policy change toward more equitable transportation systems. We focus on the following research questions:

- (1) What experiences do elected officials have with transportation barriers, and what are their understandings of barriers in their communities?
- (2) What sources of information do elected officials draw on to understand transportation barriers and inform their decision-making?
- (3) How do elected officials define and value transportation equity, and what are the implications of these values for achieving equitable policy goals?

To examine these questions, we draw on a national survey and key informant interviews with elected officials in Canadian municipalities. We begin by discussing the existing research on equity in transportation and the role of elected officials in transportation decision-making and policy change. We then focus on the demographics of elected officials in our study, including identifying their travel characteristics and as members in a structurally disadvantaged group. Following that, we examine the personal experiences that elected officials have with transportation barriers, their perception of the barriers their constituents face, and the types of information they draw on to learn about these barriers. Our findings also include an assessment of elected officials' responses to a series of forced-choice questions about different values related to transportation equity, and how this varies by demographics and experiences. We conclude by discussing the potential opportunities that arise from better understanding elected officials' perspectives on equity, and the need to address the disparities in values to inform policy change in the future.

Literature review

Understanding transportation barriers and equity

Transportation equity has long been a focus of academic research, with numerous debates about how to conceptualize, assess, and measure it (e.g., Currie, 2010; Khisty, 1996; Lucas, 2012; Pereira et al., 2017; Rowangould et al., 2016). Much research is premised on ensuring transportation benefits are fairly distributed and accessible to groups facing structural disadvantages, such as low-income individuals, women, people with disabilities, and racialized populations (e.g., Amar & Teelucksingh, 2015; Blumenberg, 2004; Foth et al., 2013; Prayitno & Moos, 2022). While the "category approach" which focuses on the travel concerns for specific groups is widely adopted, it has limitations in that groups are not homogenous and intersecting factors can greatly influence experiences (Church et al., 2000).

Understanding the nature of transportation-related barriers to full participation in society is a major focus of this research. As Church et al. (2000) describe, barriers in the transportation system can encompass a variety of areas, including physical, geographical, economic, and fear-based exclusion. These barriers are broad and often context-specific, such as those related to transportation services (e.g., lack of physically accessible services or limited service times), and experiences using transportation (e.g., how discrimination or safety issues may limit transportation options). In the Canadian context, lived experiences with transportation-related barriers have been well documented; in addition to transit service issues, safety, racialized policing and enforcement, and unaffordability of transit fares are key concerns (Linovski et al., 2021). While the need to incorporate the lived experiences of disadvantaged groups has been noted, there remains a gap in understanding if, and how, this is incorporated into decision-making processes (Lowe et al., 2023, p. 10).

Despite the extensive focus on the impacts and outcomes of transportation barriers, scholars have noted a lack of conceptual clarity in assessments (Pereira et al., 2017). While scholars argue that “a transport policy is fair if it distributes transport investments and services in ways that reduce inequality of opportunity” (Pereira et al., 2017, p. 184), this conceptualization is not universal. For example, procedural fairness focuses on processes and inclusion of impacted parties in decision-making and policy processes (Hay & Trinder, 1991), while capability approaches focus on the abilities of individuals, and broader assessments of well-being (Hananel & Berechman, 2016). Although rarely addressed in the transportation literature, political decision-making in practice may often focus on “geographic equity,” arguing that investments between jurisdictions should be equal or proportional to tax revenue (TransitCenter, 2021, p. 14).

Moving beyond theoretical conceptualizations of transportation equity, there is a body of research that examines how equity principles are negotiated and implemented in practice (Thomopoulos et al., 2009). In transportation plans and priorities, the meaningful uptake of equity issues has been mixed (Krapp et al., 2021), particularly in the Canadian context (Doran et al., 2021; Manaugh et al., 2015). U.S. transit agencies are found to have few goals that relate to low-income or transit-dependent riders, an outcome of financing and political structures (Taylor & Morris, 2015). The lack of attention may also be due in part to professional staff who often have difficulty conceptualizing transportation equity in the context of their work, and only infrequently incorporate it into planning processes (Linovski et al., 2018). In policy areas such as the equity implications of high-occupancy lanes, a lack of proactive attention from planners can make issues more politically charged (Weinstein & Sciara, 2006).

Policy learning and political decision-making

Political decision-making involves a combination of personal experiences, interactions and exposure to evidence about policymaking that influence policy actors to either change or entrench their policy beliefs and preferences over time (Heikkila & Gerlak, 2013; Weible & Cairney, 2018). Policy studies scholarship acknowledges that decision-makers often lack deep knowledge and expertise on many issues they face while in office. Many struggle to make sense of complex evidence base, and thus rely on a set of “shortcuts” when making policy decisions, using both “rational” (based on adhering to clear goals and specific types of information) and “irrational” approaches (rooted in personal habits, longstanding beliefs, emotions and gut reactions) (Cairney et al., 2016). Ideology can be instrumental in structuring attitudes to key urban issues, including housing, transportation, and density (Lucas, 2024). In the fast-paced and complex policy environment that exists in many municipalities in Canada, there is little time or incentive for policymakers to reflect and change course on a longstanding policy direction (Cairney et al., 2016). Thus, policy implementation and change require some learning on the part of decision-makers.

Policy learning includes exposure to new information and experiences which impact the knowledge and behaviors of decision-makers. As defined by Moyson and Scholten (2018, p. 7): “Policy learning is a causal mechanism linking over time the beliefs held by individual policy actors, the revision of those beliefs, the alterations of collective ideas, and policy change.” Simply, policy learning is the updating of

policy beliefs and preferences by policy actors, including elected officials (Dunlop & Radaelli, 2013). Central to the learning process is the size and quality of policy networks which influence the circulation of ideas and experiences that decision-makers are exposed to (Moyson & Scholten, 2018). Indeed, social learning and group power dynamics have long been acknowledged as relevant to policymaking in planning, which more recently has been echoed in recent calls for “researchers [to] not only draw attention to who the learning agents are but also to whom they learn from and with” (Moyson & Scholten, 2018, p. 6). Accordingly, policy learning can be viewed as a relational process that involves other policy actors, experts, personal relationships, shifting cultural values, and the decision-maker’s ability to reflect on their own beliefs and preferences (Weible & Cairney, 2018). Given that policy learning is both a social and cognitive process, understanding how policy actors in general and elected officials in particular learn policy-relevant information and make policy decisions is an important tool for professional practitioners seeking to affect policy change.

Elected officials: Transportation decision-making and policy change

While most transportation decisions and investments have some political element, there has been a lack of attention to the role of political decision-makers, particularly in policy-focused transportation research (Marsden & Reardon, 2017). Despite this, the influence of elected officials as political actors can be significant in transportation policies and investment decisions. Scholars have documented the complexity of transportation decision-making, examining the multi-scalar decisions by elected officials and stakeholders that shape outcomes (Lee, 2023). Elected officials have exercised considerable power in blocking projects they deem undesirable in their jurisdictions and manipulating professional analyses to support their preferences (Taylor et al., 2009). The need for political consensus in certain transport investment decisions, such as mode type and route, can contribute to unsubstantiated decisions (Edwards & Mackett, 1996), and entrenchment of existing transportation inequities.

The electoral pressures faced by those in public office exacerbate difficulties in shifting policies mid-course even if decisions are well-supported by compelling analysis (Dur, 2001). This is evident in U.S. metropolitan planning organizations, where those with a higher proportion of elected officials to non-elected members are found to be more focused on local, rather than regional investments, prioritizing decisions that favor their own constituents (Gerber & Gibson, 2009). For transportation initiatives that require broad voter support—such as ballot measures—“elected officials may be tempted to propose . . . projects that will attract voter support over more mundane, but necessary, system maintenance and operating expenditures” (Wachs et al., 2018, p. 5). There is also a tendency to appeal to the car-driving majority electorate (Edge et al., 2020), particularly when transit agency boards are comprised of elected officials, to the detriment of low-income and racialized transit users (Taylor & Morris, 2015; Wachs et al., 2018).

Despite their role in decision-making, understandings of elected officials’ views on transportation equity are limited. Early on, Hay and Trinder (1991) found that local councilors in England demonstrated a lack of attention to equality in outcomes, limited tolerance for subsidy levels, and often contrary interpretations in application to policy (Hay & Trinder, 1991, p. 461). In more recent research, the views and perceptions of elected officials are believed to hamper the implementation of more equitable policies. Elected officials have defined transportation benefits in the context of community-wide impacts, rather than specific benefits to transit-dependent or low-income riders (Linovski et al., 2018). In the U.S., transit administrators felt that negative and racist perceptions about transit users limited equitable policies, especially as elected officials draw on their own experiences in decision-making (Wellman, 2016). The focus on “ribbon cutting” investments in particular has long been seen as detrimental to equity-seeking groups (Grenge, 2002; Krumholz, 1982). However, with the exception of Hay and Trinder (1991), there has been little research that focuses explicitly on direct reporting from elected officials to better understand how their perspectives may affect the implementation of more equitable transportation policies.

Inequities in transportation policies may be further exacerbated by a disconnect between the demographics of transportation decision-makers and the populations they serve (Thoron, 2024). In U.S. transit agencies and state departments of transportation, White men are significantly over-represented in transit agency leadership positions, including relative to regional demographics (Agrawal et al., 2024, National Academies of Sciences Engineering and Medicine, 2007). Others have noted that “‘who decides’ and ‘who rides’ are often very different” in terms of geography, race and gender, likely resulting in inequitable spending and service decisions (TransitCenter, 2022, p. 9).¹ While little research has explicitly evaluated the implications of these discrepancies, Voulgaris et al. (2024) is a notable exception, finding that transit boards with more women were associated with more equitable service cuts during the COVID pandemic. This research largely draws on demographic characteristics (primarily race and gender), leaving room to more fully understand how specific lived experiences may influence positionality.

Context

In Canada, federal, provincial, municipal—and in some jurisdictions, regional—governments are involved in different aspects of transportation. All levels of government have key roles in funding transportation investments. Historically, federal funding investments have focused on capital and infrastructure costs, while provincial governments provide both project-specific and general-purpose funds to municipalities. While responsibility for local transportation policy and implementation—including public transit—is generally at the municipal level, municipalities are limited in their tools to raise revenue, with taxation powers granted by provincial governments and usually limited to property taxes and user fees (Kitchen et al., 2019). In this context, although local elected officials may set policy directions and priorities (albeit in compliance with relevant provincial strategies), this is often reliant on funding from other levels of government and governance models vary significantly between provinces (Horak, 2025). While this research focuses on municipal and regional elected officials, other levels of government are instrumental in shaping outcomes.

Unlike other jurisdictions, there is no specific duty in Canada to ensure transportation investments are distributed equitably or do not have undue negative impacts on protected groups (such as Title VI; Equality Act; Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms). There are equality rights set out in the Canadian Charter of Rights and Freedoms and provincial human rights legislation, which establishes protected classes and is generally enforced through the court system or tribunals. There is also federal and provincial legislation aimed at ensuring accessibility for people with disabilities (i.e., the Accessible Canada Act;² Accessibility for Ontarians with Disabilities Act; Accessibility for Manitobans Act). As in other jurisdictions, Canadian local elected officials are charged with making critical decisions about long-range planning, infrastructure, services, and resource allocation, making the findings applicable to other contexts.

Methods

This research used a mixed method approach to explore the values, experiences, and perspectives on transportation equity among local elected officials. Our study included both a national survey and key informant interviews with elected officials (mayors and councilors, or equivalent) in Canadian municipal and regional jurisdictions.³ Only elected officials (mayors and councilors) who served in communities with some form of public transit (e.g., light rail, bus, paratransit) were included to ensure comparability between respondents, and to gather information about equity in environments with multiple transportation modes.

The survey included three main themes: (1) personal experiences with transportation barriers, (2) sources of knowledge for understanding transportation issues, and (3) values related to transportation equity that were asked using multiple question structures (see Appendix 1). In addition, we asked

questions to better understand the demographics and transportation choices of respondents. The survey questions and response options were developed in consultation with members of the Mobilizing Justice research partnership (which included academics, practitioners, and community advocates) and based on the existing literature on the transportation barriers that impact quality of life in the Canadian context (e.g., Linovski et al., 2021).⁴

Potential participants were first identified through transit authority membership in the Canadian Urban Transit Association, and then web searches for transit authorities that may not have been included. All mayors and councilors in municipalities and regions with transit services were contacted. Eligible participants were sent a letter of information via e-mail by a university survey research center. Eligible participants were sent two follow up e-mails to request participation. Of the 2,148 elected officials contacted, 165 completed the survey (response rate 8.2%), representing seven provinces and one territory (see Table 1).

Following the survey, we conducted key informant interviews with respondents who indicated an interest in further participation (38 interviews, lasting between 20 minutes and 1 hour). These interviews were intended to provide more depth on the survey responses and better understand perceptions of transportation barriers and experiences. Interviews were transcribed and coded using Dedoose, a qualitative software package. We used the framework method for the coding by first developing and testing initial codes based on a sample of interviews. These codes were then assessed by multiple team members, and used to create the analytical framework for analysis (Gale et al., 2013).

Demographics and travel behavior of respondents

The demographics of survey respondents in this study are broadly similar to findings of other national surveys of local elected officials (Lucas, 2022), though the sample is not representative of national demographics (Table 2).⁵ The largest demographic group were seniors, making up over 40% of respondents, followed by women (38%). Respondents who identified as members of structurally disadvantaged groups (i.e., member of racialized, Indigenous, disability, LGBTQ+, or immigrant population) made up less than 10% of respondents.

The majority of respondents were councilors (85%), rather than mayors (15%), and represented local (89%) rather than regional (11%) governments. Most respondents also had substantial experience as elected officials, with 26% having served more than 10 years, and 30% between 5–10 years. About 40% had been in office less than one full term (29% in office 1–4 years, and 12% less than one year). Just under 50% of respondents had experience with transportation-related governance (such as serving on a transportation committee or transit agency board), which may demonstrate specific expertise in transportation issues. The respondents represented communities of different sizes, with 27% of respondents elected in the smallest municipalities (<15,000 people) and 10% from the largest municipalities (over 500,000 people) (see Table 3).⁶

As elected officials are charged with making decisions on a variety of transportation issues, we were interested in understanding their own travel experiences including their exposure to transportation

Table 1. Response rate, by province/territory.

Province	Number of Responses	% of Responses	Actual % of Population ^a
Ontario	61	37.0	38
British Columbia	54	32.7	14
Nova Scotia	16	9.7	3
Alberta	15	9.1	12
Quebec	13	7.9	23
Saskatchewan	4	2.4	3
Manitoba	1	0.6	4
Northwest Territories	1	0.6	0.1
Total	165	100	97.1^b

^a(Statistics Canada, 2022a). ^b No responses: New Brunswick, Newfoundland, Prince Edward Island, Yukon (no communities with transit service in Nunavut).

Table 2. Demographics of survey respondents, comparison with census data and other surveys.

	Respondents (%)	Comparison to Population ^a		Comparison to other surveys of elected officials	
		Statistics Canada (2022a), %	Difference	Canadian Municipal Barometer Survey, % ^f	Difference
Senior	41.2	19.0 ^c	22.2	–	–
Woman	38.5	50.7	–12.2	35.0	3.5
None of the above	22.3	–	–	–	–
Person living with disability	8.1	22.0 ^d	–13.9	–	–
LGBTQ2S+	5.4	4.0 ^e	1.4	–	–
Visible minority ^b or member of a racialized group	4.7	26.5	–21.8	4.8 ^g	– 0.1
Indigenous, Metis, Inuit, or First Nations	2.0	5.0	–3.0	1.0	1.0
Newcomer, immigrant, or refugee	2.0	23.0	–21.0	–	–

^aAll census data from (Statistics Canada, 2022a), unless otherwise noted; percentage is of valid responses.

^bThis term was used to align with Census Canada language.

^cPopulation aged 65 and older; ^d(Statistics Canada, 2022b); ^e (Statistics Canada, 2021); ^f (Lucas, 2022); percentage for women apply to population, other categories apply to sample; ^g Respondents that identify ethnic background as not White.

Table 3. Response rate, by community size.

	Population of Jurisdiction	Number of Responses	% of Responses
1	<15,000	45	27.3
2	15,000–25,000	24	14.5
3	25,000–50,000	24	14.5
4	50,000–100,000	20	12.1
5	100,000–500,000	35	21.2
6	>500,000	17	10.3
	Total	165	100

Table 4. Main mode of travel to work.

	Survey Respondents, %	Statistics Canada (2021), %	Difference
Drive (alone or carpool)	71.1	79.5	–8.4
Walk	8.1	5.5	2.6
Public Transit	6.7	12.4	–5.7
Bicycle	6.0	1.4	4.6
I did not travel to work	3.4	n/a	n/a
Other	4.0	1.2	2.8
Paratransit	0	n/a	n/a
Ride-hailing or taxi	0	n/a	n/a

Statistics Canada (2017).

barriers. To align with census data, we asked their usual mode of travel to work (prior to the start of the pandemic).⁷ The majority of respondents used a car (71%), and less than 10% used any of the other modes for travel to work (Table 4).

To give a broader picture on travel beyond work trips, we also asked their frequency of mode use for any trips (Figure 1). Similar to work trips, respondents frequently used a car for travel (61% used daily, 25% once a week or more). This broader question about travel showed more use of other modes, such as walking (28% using weekly) and biking (20% using weekly) than work trips. Use of public transit remained low even for occasional trips, and no respondents used paratransit for any trips. Given that reliable access to a car has significant impacts on mobility (e.g., Blumenberg, 2004; Klein, 2024), elected officials were asked about car ownership in their household. Of those surveyed, 90% had at least one car (owned or leased) in their household, while less than 10% of respondents did not have any car in their household.

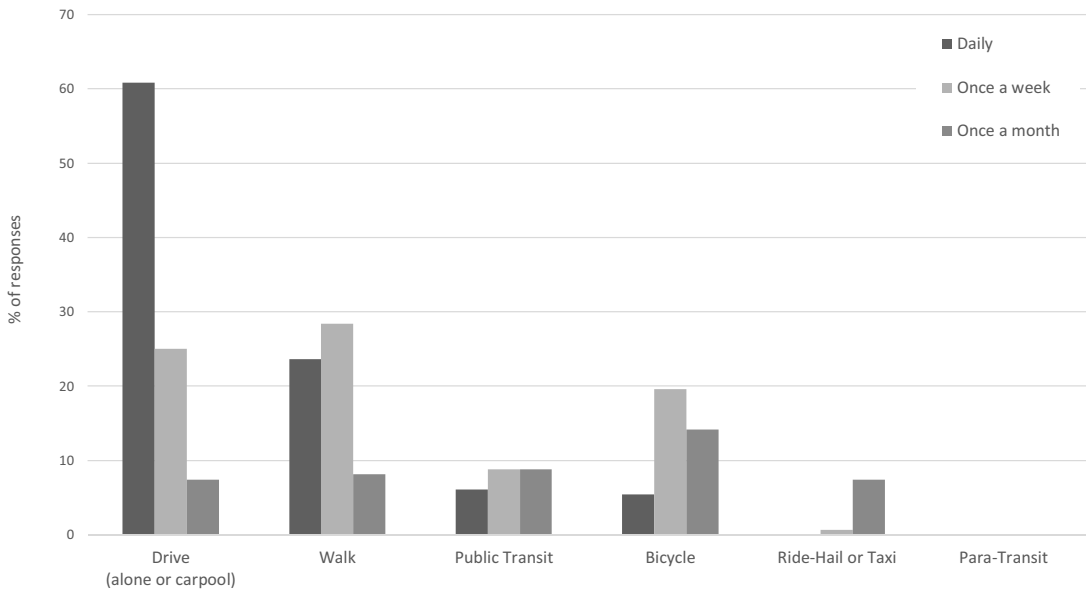


Figure 1. Mode frequency for any trip.

Limitations

The response rate was on the lower end for direct recruitment surveys and could be due to the length of the survey (respondents spent on average 25 minutes to complete) or timing (before local elections in several provinces). Declining response rates from elected officials have been noted as an issue more broadly in research as online surveys become more ubiquitous (Krause et al., 2023). There is an issue of self-selection for the surveys and interviews, as participants may be more likely to have strong feelings about transportation issues. There were few respondents that identified as racialized, having a disability, Indigenous, LGBTQ, or as an immigrant. While we feel this accurately reflects the demographics of local elected officials (Lucas, 2022), it limited our ability to analyze the relationship between identity and values. However, as exploratory research—with limited previous analyses of these issues—the findings can still offer insight into key issues for understanding the views of elected officials.

Findings

Personal experience with transportation barriers

Elected officials reported limited personal experience with common transportation barriers but many had someone important to them facing barriers (see Figure 2). For example, only 5% of respondents had transportation issues related to a disability, but 41% have someone important to them that does. The most common directly experienced barriers that elected officials reported were related to public transit (such as not serving needed destinations or other service issues) and long commute times. Few elected officials noted that they had faced barriers related to transportation costs (both for transit and private transportation), walking or cycling, or harassment. In contrast, over 50% of respondents have someone important to them that face barriers related to the cost of private transportation, and over 40% know someone with difficulties walking or cycling. Elected officials had the least experience (either direct or someone close to them) with harassment (7% direct experience, 22% someone they know) or inability to afford public transit costs (6% direct experience, 21% someone they know).

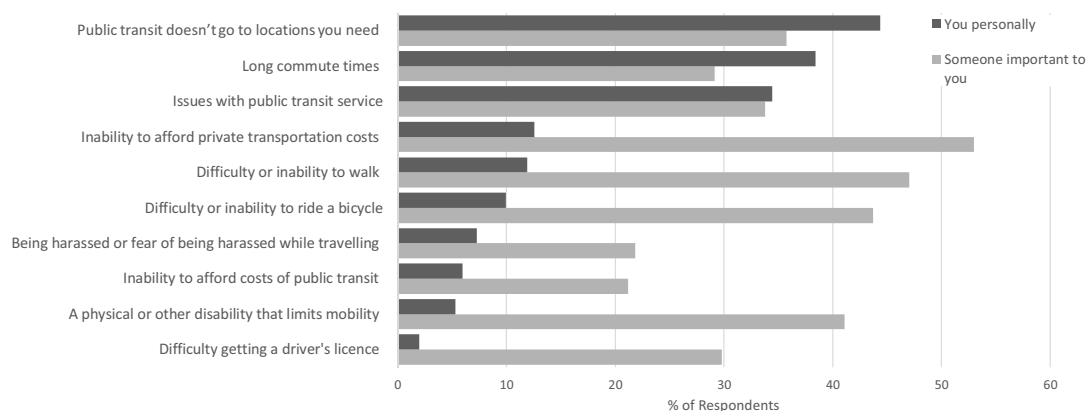


Figure 2. Elected officials' experience with transportation barriers.

Perceptions of transportation barriers and impacted communities

To further explore elected officials' understanding of transportation barriers, we asked participants to rank the most significant barriers they felt that people in their jurisdiction face (Table 5).⁸ We found both similarities and differences between respondents' own experiences and those they felt constituents faced. For example, elected officials felt that the most common barriers for constituents related to public transit, either long travel times or being unable to reach destinations, which was similar to their personal experiences noted above (both selected by 80% of respondents as a barrier). Both of these were also selected by the most participants as the *top* barrier. Respondents also felt that high costs of car ownership are a barrier for their constituents (selected by 59% of respondents), though few saw this as the top barrier. Safety issues for active transportation were also selected frequently as a barrier (58%). Just as few elected officials had direct experience with harassment, few felt that their constituents faced these barriers (13% selected discrimination as a barrier, 14% selected safety issues on transit, and no participants selected either as a top barrier). Similarly, the cost of public transit was not seen by many elected officials as a significant barrier for their constituents (22% as a barrier, 3% as the top barrier).

Respondents' perceptions varied according to the size of community they represent (see Figure 3). For example, respondents from smaller communities were the only participants that selected long travel times by car as the most important barrier, or that there were no significant barriers for constituents in their jurisdictions. Conversely, more elected officials from larger communities

Table 5. Perception of transportation barriers for constituents.

	Selected as a barrier (any rank), %	Selected as <i>most important</i> barrier, %
Long travel times to get places by public transit	80	39
Unable to reach destinations by public transit	80	27
High costs of car ownership	59	7
Safety issues while walking, biking, or rolling	58	10
Long travel times to get places by personal vehicle	31	1
Inability to afford transit fares	22	3
Safety issues while driving	21	1
Safety issues while using public transit	14	0
Discrimination based on gender, age, sexuality, race, or ability while using public transit, walking or biking	13	0
No significant barriers	10	4
Other barrier	21	8

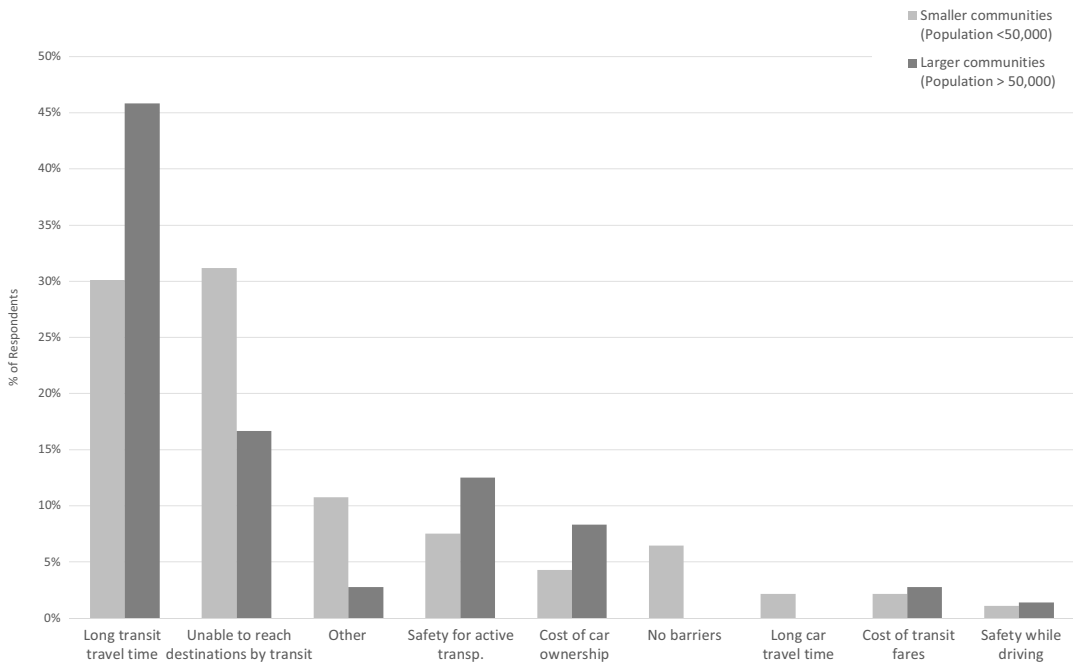


Figure 3. Most important barrier, by community size.

identified the cost of car ownership, safety for active transportation, and long transit travel times as the most significant barrier.

We conducted follow up interviews to better understand how elected officials perceive which communities are impacted by transportation barriers. This question was selected for interview follow-up so respondents would develop their own responses, rather than be primed with list of options. We asked interviewees: “In the survey, we asked about transportation barriers that people in your community face. What populations or groups of people do you think of when considering transportation barriers?” (Table 6). The most common group identified as facing barriers were people with disabilities (noted by 66% of interviewees), with most of these officials referring to physical disabilities (20 out of 25). Next frequently mentioned groups were those with low incomes (58% of interviewees), and seniors (45%).

A small number of interview participants discussed communities facing barriers using intersectional approaches. For example, as a councilor from a large region discussed:

Table 6. Perception of communities facing transportation barriers.

Community or Group	# of Respondents Identified (out of 38 total)	% of Respondents
People with disabilities	25	66%
People with low income	22	58%
Seniors	17	45%
Youth or students	10	26%
Immigrants or newcomers	9	24%
Intersectional understandings	7	18%
Racialized, visible minority	5	13%
Women	3	8%
Indigenous people	2	5%
Parents	2	5%
No access to a car	13	34%
Land use or housing issues	9	24%

We have a very significantly growing newcomer population, which you know, they're coming as refugees. They're coming as new immigrants. They're coming as folks [for] who English is a second language. They don't feel necessarily comfortable, due to the racism or the sexism, and exhibited violence on transit. (Interview 23, community size = 5)

Around a third of interviewees noted barriers not specifically related to identity characteristics or protected classes, including no access to a car (for a variety of reasons, including no license, medical condition, or cost) and land use or housing issues (such as lack of affordable housing near transit or rural transit issues). For example, a councilor in a large region focused on housing affordability and lack of transit when asked about communities that face barriers:

Our de facto affordable housing strategy for decades was "we'll let developers build on cheap land in the suburbs, and they'll build cheap housing, and that'll be affordable for people." The problem is, you push people out further and further from the core and so our transit system is not as accessible or frequent as out there, as it is, say, in the urban core. You end up pushing people who can't afford to have private transportation options into an area where they have limited public transportation. (Interview 26, size = 5)

Communities that are frequently addressed in the academic literature, such as immigrants, women, and racialized people were not commonly noted by elected officials. Only two respondents specifically addressed First Nations or Indigenous people, including one councilor who said: "we've been working hand in hand, government to government, to make sure that services consider the needs of Indigenous residents, both on reserve and off reserve" (Interview 8, size = 3).

The groups identified by elected officials as facing barriers also varied by community size. Elected officials in the larger municipalities (50,000 people and greater) discussed people with low incomes more frequently (75%) than those in smaller communities (33%). Immigrants were also more frequently mentioned by those in larger cities (30%, compared with 13% in smaller municipalities), though those in smallest communities discussed migrant workers specifically. Conversely, officials in smaller communities discussed seniors more frequently (60%), compared with those in large municipalities (35%). People with disabilities were addressed with similar frequency by those in small (60%) and large (69%) communities.

In addition to broad information about the groups considered, the interviews offered more insight into how elected officials may develop understandings of transportation barriers. Some drew on their own experiences, such as this example from a mayor:

Well, I think of all of our population when I think of transportation. Barriers would certainly be physical accessibility . . . A lot of us came from [PROVINCE] and retired here. So, we have a lot of people who are who are older, who would, of course, have mobility issues. Some are quite elderly, and we have to think about that. (Interview 36, size = 1)

Others drew on knowledge they gained directly from constituents, such as this councilor:

I had a woman who got in touch with me, and she was 96, and her son was living with her, and they were living in a mobile home. They were out of food, and they didn't have transportation. And that's a fairly common thing for me to see. (Interview 38, size = 2)

In contrast, another councilor from a small municipality specifically noted that councilors may have less direct experience with transportation barriers:

I think about the age barriers, the ability barriers, the financial barriers, and the mental habits barrier . . . The people in power are often older people. And there's been a lot of discussion about that recently here, about how it's very hard to have a job and be a councilor. So, it's mostly retired people or people who can do without an income for a while. And those people are in the habit of thinking, you know, that everybody has a house and a car. Well, not everybody has both, and not everybody has either. (Interview 19, size = 2)

While most elected officials did not comment on how they knew about barriers in the interviews, these examples offer insight into the varying sources of information that may be used to develop their understandings, as detailed below.

Information sources about transportation barriers for constituents

In addition to any personal experiences with transportation barriers, we were interested in how local officials learn about transportation barriers from their constituents. As elected representatives may not have similar experiences to their constituents, their sources of information can be an important factor in decision-making. Respondents most frequently rely on information from staff to understand constituent barriers, with 81% regularly using staff reports or similar (see Figure 4). Other important sources of information were constituents themselves, through e-mails, phone calls, or meetings with individual constituents (66% use regularly) and public meetings or open houses (60% use regularly). Associations were less frequently seen as a source of information (47% for constituent associations and 40% for advocacy groups). Professional surveys, social media, and traditional media were used regularly by less than a third of respondents.⁹

Values about equity

To better understand personal values related to equity, we asked elected officials a series of forced choice questions (Table 7). These questions were designed to cover the common theoretical and practical approaches to transportation equity such as procedural fairness, utilitarianism, and geographic fairness discussed above (e.g., Pereira et al., 2017; Trinder et al., 1991) (Questions 1–4), as well as common issues in transportation-related decision-making (Questions 5–6). While the interpretations of these frameworks cannot be fully covered in a short statement, the responses give insight into broad values that may impact how transportation equity decisions are made by respondents.¹⁰

The strongest support from respondents was for the need to change existing conditions (such as transportation costs or changes to infrastructure) to ensure fairness, with 84% agreeing with this statement. The question set with the second highest level of agreement, was on willingness to pay costs. For this set, 77% of respondents felt that car users should be required to pay for the full costs of driving, while only 23% supported transit users paying full costs. While these two question sets had the most consensus from respondents, they also do not explicitly address equity-deserving, marginalized or identity-specific groups.¹¹ There was also strong support for procedural fairness as it relates to public consultation, with 73% of respondents agreeing that “public consultation is only fair if people with different identities and from different communities are able to fully participate.”

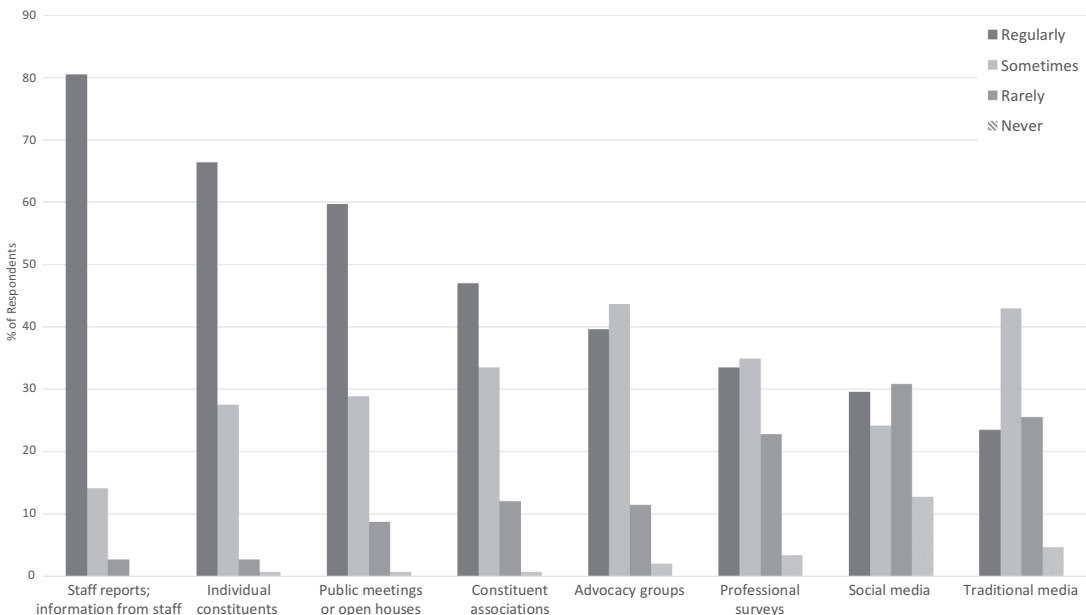


Figure 4. Sources of knowledge about constituent transportation barriers.

Table 7. Equity values: Framework, options, and responses^a, (Most selected option highlighted).

	Framework	Option 1		Option 2	
1	Procedural Fairness	Public consultation is only fair if people from different identities and communities are able to fully participate.	73%	If people choose not to participate in public consultation, that does not impact the fairness of the process.	27%
2	Mode Choice Fairness	Regardless of what mode people travel by, they should be able to reach the destinations they need, with similar time, costs, and comfort.	66%	People choosing to travel by transit, biking or walking can expect that their trips may take longer, be less comfortable, or cost more than traveling by car.	34%
3	Geographic Fairness	All areas of the city/region should receive similar levels of investment.	44%	Investment should be prioritized in areas of the city/region that have historically not received the same level of investment as other areas.	56%
4	Utilitarian	Transportation policies should provide benefits to the greatest number of people.	63%	Transportation policies should be prioritized to benefit marginalized people and communities.	37%
5	Maintenance of Existing Conditions	For transportation systems to be fair, existing costs and infrastructure that people have come to expect should remain the same as much as possible.	16%	For transportation systems to be fair, sometimes changes to existing costs (i.e., parking, bus fares) or infrastructure (i.e., adding bike or bus lanes at the expense of car traffic) are needed.	84%
6	Willingness to Pay	Car users should be required to pay the full costs of the infrastructure required for driving (roads, parking, and bridges).	77%	Public transit should be provided only if people are willing to pay the full cost of it.	23%

^aNon-response for the values questions ranged from 0.6–3.6% with the exception of Q6 (willingness to pay full costs), which 25 participants (15%) did not answer. Percentages in table do not include non-responses.

There was less consensus in responses to the other question sets, and overall, less support for values associated with common equity frameworks. While much academic discourse and policy guidance has focused on addressing the needs of equity-deserving groups, only 37% of respondents agreed that “transportation policies should be prioritized to benefit marginalized people and communities.” There was a similar split on the question related to travel mode, with 34% of respondents agreeing that “people choosing to travel by transit, biking or walking can expect that their trips may take longer, be less comfortable, or cost more than traveling by car.” Lastly, respondents were almost evenly split on issues of geographic fairness, with 44% of respondents agreeing that “all areas of the city/region should receive similar levels of investment,” rather than targeting areas that have historically not received the same level of investment.

Personal experiences and differences in equity values

We found that the level of support for equity values varied based on (1) differing experiences with transportation barriers, (2) demographic or identity characteristics, and (3) community size. For this analysis, we focused on the utilitarian fairness question, which asked respondents to choose between targeting resources to benefit marginalized groups or providing benefits to the greatest number of people (Table 7, Question 4). This was analyzed further as the focus on benefitting structurally-disadvantaged groups most closely represents professional, academic, and regulatory constructions of transportation equity (TransitCenter, 2021; Yan, 2013), yet received little overall support (37%) from elected officials.

Respondents who had either personal experience with a transportation barrier or someone important to them with experience, valued prioritizing marginalized groups more frequently than those without either of these experiences (see Figure 5).¹² For example, over 90% of those who valued prioritizing marginalized groups had someone close to them experiencing a transportation barrier, compared with 73% of those who valued benefiting the greatest number of people. For demographic characteristics, the differences in values were starkest when assessed by gender, with women making up a larger share (60%) of those that prioritized policies benefiting marginalized groups, compared with those noting other identity characteristics (16%–36%) (see Figure 6).¹³ All other elected officials,

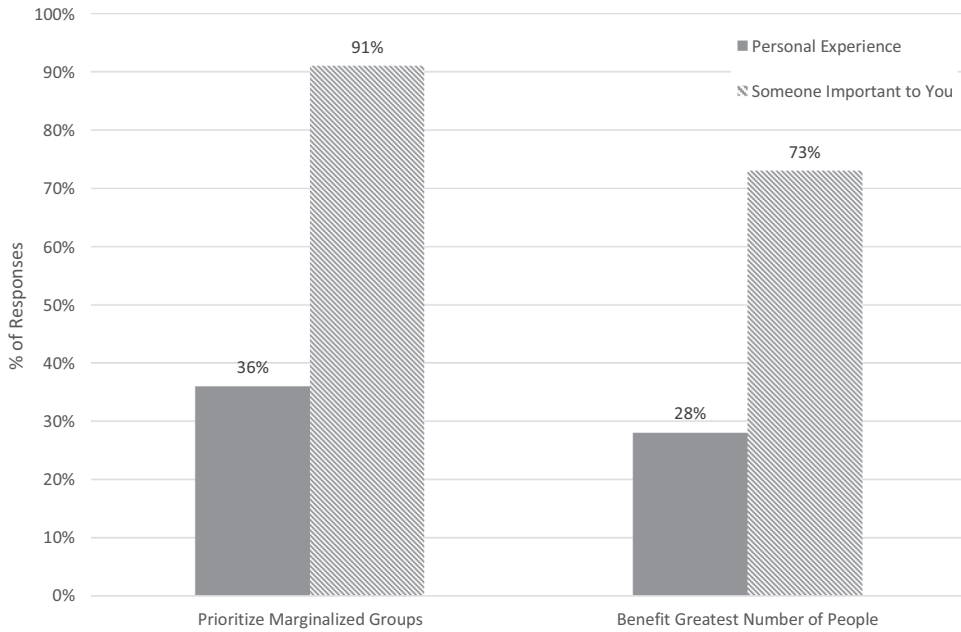
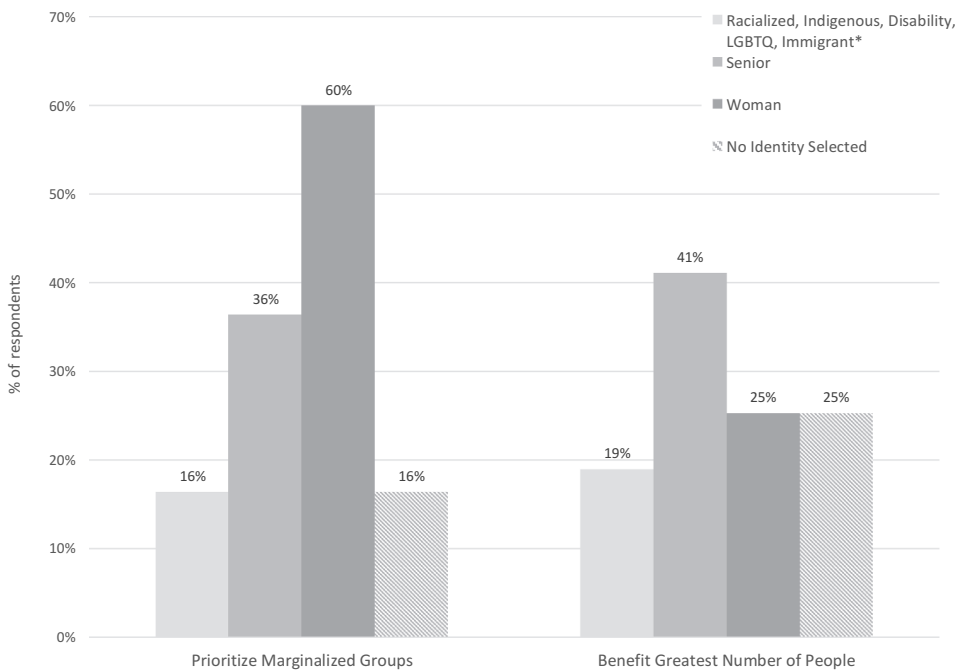


Figure 5. Responses to utilitarian fairness, by personal experiences.



* Grouped due to low responses in each group

Figure 6. Responses to utilitarian fairness, by identity characteristics.

including those who identified as seniors or did not identify as part of an equity-seeking group, valued utilitarian values more frequently than equity values.

There were also differences in values depending on community size. Those in the largest municipalities (>500,000) had the most support for prioritizing marginalized groups (50%), compared to less than a quarter (21%) of respondents from mid-sized cities (100,000–500,000), and an average of 38% support for those from smallest municipalities (>100,000). There were no substantial differences in values among those who served on transportation committees or transit agency boards, or used non-car modes more frequently.

Discussion

Direct experience and sources of information: Limitations and opportunities

When making decisions, policy actors draw on their own beliefs, personal characteristics, and experiences (Koop & Conrad, 2021; Ralph & Delbosc, 2017), which are heavily influenced by exposure to ideas and experiences from those in their network (Moyson & Scholten, 2018). While having transportation decision-makers with more diverse experiences may potentially result in more equitable outcomes (TransitCenter, 2022), there has been limited research that explores this relationship (Voulgaris et al., 2024). Our findings show that elected officials who have personal experience with transportation barriers, as well as those who have certain identity characteristics, prioritize equity values and the transport needs of equity-deserving groups more frequently.

These findings point to specific concerns for increasing transportation equity. The majority of participants' direct experiences with transportation barriers were related to transportation system design and implementation, such as transit destinations, rather than those closely aligned with personal characteristics such as harassment (e.g., race or religion) or accessibility (e.g., disability). In fact, few of the widely recognized transportation barriers in Canada—such as affordability, discrimination, and harassment (Linovski et al., 2021)—were even identified as concerns by elected officials in this study. As others have argued, there is a need to help decision-makers better understand the travel experiences of others (Delbosc, 2020; Ralph & Delbosc, 2017). Despite limited direct experience, many elected officials do have someone close to them who experienced transportation barriers, which may offer an opportunity to increase understanding and possibly action on key equity issues.¹⁴ Strategies that broaden elected officials' policy network and enhance their exposure to experiences of a diversity of residents, not just those in their ward, may also help inform decision-making and result in future policy change (Heikkila & Gerlak, 2013; Weible & Cairney, 2018). This study lays the groundwork for future longitudinal research that explores how, when, and under what conditions policy learning influences the beliefs and values related to transportation equity among elected officials, and whether policy learning further entrenches or changes policy preferences over time (Dunlop & Radaelli, 2013).

Encouragingly, this study found strong support from elected officials for procedural fairness, with 73% agreeing that public consultation is only fair if people from different identities and communities are able to fully participate. While the limits of traditional public engagement have been noted (Karner & Marcantonio, 2018; Linovski & Baker, 2023; Lubitow et al., 2021), practitioners should make concerted efforts to ensure that the experiences of structurally disadvantaged communities are prioritized in data collection, analysis, and recommendations to council. As elected officials frequently rely on staff reports to understand barriers that their constituents face, this underscores the importance of other policy actors, such as planning and transportation staff, in influencing decision-making. However, as stated by community advocates,¹⁵ staff reports are only helpful if those developing them are committed to learning from the experiences of structurally disadvantaged groups and prioritizing equity as a policy goal. Planners and other staff have a role to play as policy actors in ensuring that their reports, analysis, and public events are inclusive, and that their recommendations reflect the needs and priorities of equity-deserving groups.

Potential role of regulatory framework

In our interviews, elected officials most frequently discussed people with disabilities as facing transportation barriers, regardless of community size. While few elected officials had direct experience with a disability (5% of survey respondents, 4 out of 38 interview participants), this was often discussed in-depth, noting different types of disabilities, the intersection with factors such as age, and in specific contexts, such regional travel. These findings are important in the context of the limited legislative duty to address equity in Canadian municipalities. As noted above, there are few regulatory directives to ensure equality in transportation outcomes and services, aside from provincial accessibility legislation.¹⁶ Our findings underscore the need for further research on the potential for regulations to shape equitable outcomes, particularly in how elected officials view their public duty. While there may be concerns with how equity statutory duties are implemented (Yan, 2013), they may provide a common or shared understanding of goals and duties.

Lack of common shared understanding

One of the critical findings is a significant disconnect between academic and professional understandings of equity and the values of many elected officials. Academic analyses almost exclusively focus on equity-deserving groups, such as race, Indigenous identity, disability, immigrant status, and gender identity (e.g., Deboosere & El-Geneidy, 2018; Foth et al., 2013; Morency et al., 2011). Similarly, policy guidelines in various jurisdictions and by advocacy organizations specifically emphasize the need to evaluate the impacts of policies and programs on equity-deserving communities (e.g., City of Ottawa & City for All Women Initiative, 2018; TransitCenter, 2021). For example, guidance to transit agencies notes this as fundamental to transportation equity:

An equity strategy should outline how to prioritize the needs of people who have been marginalized from the transportation system and to repair past and current harms. The purpose should be achieving a transit system that provides service proportional to need—not “equal” service to all. (TransitCenter, 2021, p. 14, emphasis added)

Yet, we found only 37% overall of elected officials agreed that transportation policies should be prioritized to benefit marginalized people and communities, rather than the greatest number of people, and this varied significantly based on elected officials’ own experiences and identities. The gap between professional/academic discourses and political values may have important implications for achieving more equitable transportation outcomes, particularly in how professionals advocate for equitable policies and investments. Future research would benefit from more direct and explicit engagement with elected officials early in the process to ensure relevance and uptake of findings in practice (Cairney et al., 2016; Marsden & Reardon, 2017).

While there are differing conceptions of transportation equity among academics and advocates, these findings point to the need to have more foundational discussions with elected officials about why those most impacted by transportation barriers should be considered and prioritized in decision-making. As noted with some transportation issues, there is a role for other policy actors, such as staff and senior leadership, to be proactive in addressing equity issues and shaping the terms of the debate, particularly when issues may be politically charged (Weinstein & Sciara, 2006). Although more research here is needed, the focus may include contextually-specific histories of transportation inequities and the significant impact that transportation barriers have on full participation in society. As many elected officials do not have direct or even indirect experience with many types of transportation barriers, it is critical to engage in policy learning early, before elected officials are charged with making decisions.

Conclusions

Despite the pivotal role that elected officials have in shaping transportation investments, there has been relatively little research into their values related to equity. As exploratory research, this work

provides a national overview, drawing on responses from Canadian elected officials in different geographic, policy, and community contexts, as well as further insights from key informant interviews. While previous research has largely omitted drawing directly on the experiences and values of elected officials to understand issues with implementing more equitable transportation policies, our findings show that this offers important implications. Elected officials may have little direct experience with transportation barriers, with few experiencing issues such as affordability, disabilities, or harassment, and evidence that this influences their values related to equity. When asked about communities facing transportation barriers, the majority of elected officials focused on people with disabilities, low-income, and seniors, with less than a quarter of participants noting any other group. While there was widespread support for procedural equity, the elected officials surveyed were divided on prioritizing marginalized communities, which is the largely the foundation for academic and professional practice.

Views on elected officials and transportation decision-making can lack nuance, particularly in understanding their motivations. For example, early guidance on communicating with local politicians about transportation issues states that: “It is a world of competing imperatives, and elected officials have a need to satisfy the constituency group(s) that put them in office. This often calls for short-term results that are visible and understood by the public . . .” (Mason, 2005, p. 21). While research has noted the lack of diversity in transportation decision-makers (Thoron, 2024; TransitCenter, 2022; Voulgaris et al., 2024), it is necessary to understand more deeply the motivations and values of elected officials as key policy actors, and whether it is possible to shift policy beliefs to affect change over time (Weible & Cairney, 2018). Our research points to the need for transportation professionals and advocates to engage more directly with elected officials about transportation barriers faced by constituents to inform future transportation policies and investment decisions. By drawing directly on the values and experiences of elected officials, and situating transportation decision-making in the political contexts within which it occurs, this research offers insight for practitioners, policymakers, and others charged with implementing more equitable transportation systems.

Notes

1. Much of the research on diversity in transit leadership does not distinguish between elected officials, politically-appointed positions, and senior staff, as well as addressing race, ethnicity or gender, rather than specific experiences.
2. Federal accessibility legislation only applies to federally regulated transportation industries (air, rail, inter-provincial bus, and some ferries), and not municipal transportation services, which are under provincial jurisdiction.
3. The survey was open from June–September 2022. Interviews were conducted between January–March 2023.
4. For more information on the Mobilizing Justice partnership and members, see <https://mobilizingjustice.ca>.
5. There is little national data on the demographics of municipal politicians, particularly for characteristics like disability, sexual diversity (Mévellec et al., 2020), or immigrant status. One study that looked at the 23 largest cities in Ontario, found that of those elected to council, 27.9% were women, 19.3% were foreign-born, and 7.6% were visible minorities, a significant under-representation of the population (Bird, 2016, p. 183).
6. The lower number of responses from larger municipalities is expected as there are only 34 cities with a population greater than 100,000 in Canada.
7. There is limited national travel data collected in Canada. The census includes questions about travel to work only, including mode and destination.
8. Participants could select and rank up to five options. Other responses included issues like winter conditions, difficult topography, and land use/densities that make it difficult to support transit.
9. Three respondents included write-in answers, which included consulting subject matter experts, reports and studies, and census data.
10. For example, while there are multiple aspects of procedural fairness in transportation planning and implementation, the survey options focus on fairness in public consultations.
11. Of all the question sets, 2, 3, 5, and 6 have no reference to equity-deserving groups.
12. For this analysis, we included person-specific barriers (such as disability, inability to afford transportation costs, harassment), rather than community-wide ones (public transit service issues, long commute times).
13. As respondents could select more than one characteristic, totals do not sum to 100%.

14. While elected officials had more indirect experience with transportation barriers (someone close to them experiencing a barrier) than personal experience, this does not necessarily mean they have exposure to a diversity of experiences (i.e., the experiences of people from different income groups, racial or ethnic communities).
15. Preliminary findings of this research were presented to an advisory group (Community and Equity Advisory Table) affiliated with the Mobilizing Justice project.
16. In some provinces, the transportation sector (including municipal transit) has been subject to specific standards to ensure accessibility (i.e., Transportation Standard, Accessibility for Ontarians with Disabilities Act; Accessible Transportation Standard Regulation, Accessible Manitoba Act).

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Samantha Leger is a PhD candidate in the School of Planning at the University of Waterloo, with a previous master's degree in interdisciplinary urban design from the Bartlett School of Planning, University College London. Her research interests revolve around mobility justice and designing inclusive streetscapes. She is also a registered professional planner candidate member with 4+ years of experience in transportation and urban planning. Through both her practical and academic roles, Samantha is a passionate advocate of the critical intersections between transportation, urban design, and public health and centers her work on the paths toward more just mobilities futures.

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